

its reliance on Aptitude-based tasks for installing bulk packages at once, instead of Ubuntu's meta-package approach, left me floundering for a while. For example, Ubuntu's desktop meta-package is called *ubuntu-desktop*, and I can install it with a simple `apt-get install ubuntu-desktop`. Debian has no such meta-package, and requires the installation of two 'tasks', *desktop* and *gnome-desktop*. Note that these are *tasks*, and `apt-get` will fail to install these with *No Package Found* errors. You'll have to use Aptitude for these. It's not a bug; it's actually a more elegant solution, since removing the task will remove all packages too, unlike removing the meta-package, where all the actual packages remain, making no difference to the installation. Still, it does take a bit of getting used to.

On the upside, the sheer amount of software that Debian's default repositories hold never ceases to amaze. Even though Network Manager is installed by default, Wicd is available, as is the Linux Container system LXC, and the cluster framework Corosync. In fact, between Lenny and Squeeze, 10,000 additional packages have been added. Even Dockey is available in the default repos!

Talking about repos, note that the repositories for the next release of Debian (7.0 Wheezy) have already been defined. However, don't get too excited—even though it's installable and fully functional, the actual release is another two years away.

And last, but not the least: Remmina replaces Vinagre and RDesktop, giving you one unified remote-desktop client. Remmina currently supports VNC, RDP, XDMCP, NX and SSH connections, so that's a huge improvement over Vinagre. The default desktop also includes some sort of a time management tool, which is something I didn't bother trying out.

The server end

Debian 6.0 is a perfectly capable server system. In fact, it was meant to be a server system right from the start. The server end is also where the *kfreebsd* variants make themselves useful. Since without the desktop environments, the sources of bugs are done away with, the FreeBSD kernel should actually be a better choice for servers than Linux.

So can Debian 6.0 run Drupal 7? I'm using Drupal 7 as a benchmark because it's just been released, and the requirements are pretty high for servers, especially since MySQL versions earlier than 5.0.15 aren't supported. Well, Apache 2.2.16 and MySQL 5.1.49, with PHP 5.3.3, takes care of Drupal 7. Unfortunately, MariaDB packages aren't available yet, but official DEBs from MariaDB's website are, which can be installed.

Debian actually includes three different versions of Python: 2.5.5 and 2.6.6, with the latter being the default, while 3.1.3 is also included. I'm scratching my head as

to what sin the 2.7 branch committed, leading to it being left out...

As for virtualisation support, though KVM has been ported to FreeBSD, I couldn't find the related package (*qemu-kvm*) for the *kfreebsd* releases.

Moving on, Samba 3.5.6 makes it to the release. Samba 4 packages are available in Experimental (as well as Sid). Apache Tomcat version 6.0.18 and Nagios 3.2.3 complete the rest of the tool-kit. Oh, and Perl is at 5.10 (5.12 is available with Experimental).

Lastly, AppArmor isn't included in Debian 6, and the only way to somehow have it is by compiling a custom 2.6.36 kernel. SELinux is available, but not installed or enabled by default.

Experimental and Backports

Debian is Debian because of its strict policy of including only stable and known-to-work packages. This means the packages are always somewhat old. While, most of the time, stability is the priority for Debian users, sometimes you just need that new version of a package, and it just doesn't appear in this Debian release. Debian doesn't have things like Ubuntu's PPAs, but it does have two officially sanctioned repositories that deliver updated packages: Backports and Experimental.

Backports

When a package is deemed to be mature and stable enough in the development cycle of the upcoming release (or Sid, if there is no upcoming release yet), Debian tries to back-port the package to the current release. If it works well—meaning that no more than just a few dependencies need to be back-ported along with the package in question (and also, those few dependencies don't include any core packages, such as *EGlibc* or *GTK+*)—then the back-port is made available via the Debian Backports repository.

There are a few caveats to using Backports. Debian plays it safe, so you can only add the Backports repository, not enable it. Hang on—if you can't enable the repo, how on earth do you use packages from it? Well, Backports is implemented as another release, so you'll have to ask Apt or Aptitude to target the *squeeze-backports* release to download packages from it. System policy prevents Debian from automatically fetching updates to every single package on the system from Backports, but once you install something from Backports, you'll receive updates to those packages all right.

Experimental

Experimental is for daredevils. When a package first enters the Debian Project, its entry point is Experimental. While it's in Experimental, it's stabilised to a point where it can enter Sid, and then be back-ported to other releases. The thing is, you don't want to be using packages from